

Confusing words

SIMILAR-SOUNDING WORDS CAN BE DIFFICULT TO SPELL.

English includes many words that look and sound the same, or nearly the same. Recognizing small differences in pronunciation can help with spelling.

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◀ 142–143 Prefixes and suffixes

◀ 162–163 Compound words

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Noun and verb confusion

Some nouns and verbs are often confused because of their similar or identical pronunciation. In some cases, a small change in the sound of a word can indicate a different part

of speech, as in the noun *advice* and verb *advise*. More often, however, words have the same pronunciation but a different spelling and meaning, as in *effect* and *affect*.

advice

This noun refers to guidance.

or

advise

This verb means to offer suggestions.

Their **advice** was helpful.

I asked her to **advise** me.

altar

This noun refers to a table in a church.

or

alter

This verb means to change something.

The priest stood at the **altar**.

He tried to **alter** the results.

breath

This noun refers to air taken in or out of the lungs.

or

breathe

This verb means to take air in and out of the lungs.

She took a deep **breath**.

He had to **breathe** hard while jogging.

ceiling

This noun refers to the upper surface of a room.

or

sealing

This verb means to close securely.

The new light hung from the **ceiling**.

The plumber is **sealing** the gap.

device

This noun refers to a piece of equipment.

or

devise

This verb means to plan or invent.

I bought a new phone **device**.

The team will **devise** a website.

effect

This noun refers to the result of an action.

or

affect

This verb means to have an impact on.

The protest had a positive **effect**.

The fight **affected** him badly.